Andhra Pradesh. Remarkably few early human remains have been found in India, for which the Indian porcupine's fondness for chewing old bones may be partly responsible, but a decade ago fragments of burnt human bone and one tooth from the Pleistocene era were uncovered by an international team led by Michael Petraglia, Chris Clarkson and Ravi Korisettar while excavating the floor of a rock-shelter at the base of a large boulder known as Jwalapuram Locality 9.[14] The proliferation of microliths (worked stone flakes used as tools or weapon heads), beads and worked bone showed that the site had been in more or less continuous occupation since about thirty-five thousand years ago. When the river-bed itself was dug into at a number of points a thick layer of volcanic ash was found, beginning some 7 feet under the ground surface: the fallout from the Toba volcano. At two of these sites microliths were uncovered both above and below the ash, which led the authors of the subsequent reports to conclude that this was evidence of human occupation in India prior to the Toba eruption – conclusions since challenged by another team of archaeologists, who have shown (to me, very convincingly) that the microliths uncovered below the ash belt at Jwalapuram are far cruder than those above, which are strikingly similar to well-worked microliths found in South African sites dating from sixty-five thousand years ago and after. This suggests that the cruder microliths found under the ash layer were the work of archaic hominid species such as *Homo erectus*, and the more refined microliths above the ash the work of the first fully human migrants out of Africa.[15]

Jwalapuram is exceptional in containing perhaps the oldest and most enduring microlithic sequence yet found in India but it is only one of a number of sites that are now beginning to reveal the secrets of early human migration in India. Rivers provided the easiest access into the interior